

EARLY MODERN WORKSHOP: Jewish History Resources

Volume 16: Senses and Perceptions

Fordham University, New York, August 19-20, 2019

Controlling the Senses: Social Propriety and Religious Achievement: Joseph Ergas' *Pri Megadim*

Bernard Cooperman, University of Maryland

Introduction

Characteristic of the Jewish spiritual and pietistic revival centered in sixteenth-century Safed was a call for the ritualization of every-day life thus to expand the religious experience into every aspect of the quotidian. Even the most pedestrian of sensations and bodily activities was to be elevated through an intricate web of axioms, definitions, and associations. The call now was for the public performance and demonstration of piety with the body.

Made possible by the increasing availability of inexpensive print books, a literature soon developed to promote the new approach. We can see the process in the opening paragraph of the composite work we generally refer to collectively as the *Shulhan Arukh*. The paragraph that begins with Caro's summary of Jacob ben Asher's original statement is then expanded by Moses Isserles' quotations from Maimonides, building to an interpretation of Ps 16:8: "I shall imagine the Lord before me always." For the medieval Maimonides the verse had been a call for individual control of public behavior. But already in the *Beit Yosef*, his ample commentary on Ben-Asher's *Tur*, Joseph Caro had turned the discussion by introducing the idea that public shame might deter open piety. Now Moses Isserles, in his "Additions," expanded the opening turning it into a firm demand for unhesitant public religious display: "Do not be ashamed before people who mock your worship of God."¹ Thus we see the gradual reinterpretation of old texts into new pietistic demands, an example of the general process highlighted by Jacob

¹ Jeffrey Woolf provides an overview in "La'avodat Bor'o: The Body in the Shulhan Arukh of R. Joseph Caro," in Giuseppe Veltri and Maria Diemling, eds., *The Jewish Body: Corporeality, Society, and Identity in the Renaissance and Early Modern Period* (Leiden: Brill, 2009). On the issue more broadly see, e.g., Lawrence Fine, "Purifying the Body in the Name of the Soul: The Problem of the Body in Sixteenth-Century Kabbalah," in *People of the Body: Jews and Judaism from an Embodied Perspective*, ed. H. Eilberg-Schwartz (Albany: SUNY Press, 1992), pp. 117–142 and Elliot Wolfson, "The Body in the Text: A Kabbalistic Theory of Embodiment," *Jewish Quarterly Review* 95 (2005), pp. 497 – 500.

Katz through which the *Shulhan Arukh* became a major vehicle for the insertion of kabbalistic considerations into halakhic practice.

Gradually specialized guides and manuals appeared that sought to teach individuals the new religious requirements. What is referred to as “*hanhagot* literature” seems to have emerged first out of the active religious ferment in Safed.² But as Ze'ev Gries has pointed out in seminal articles, we are talking about more than a local phenomenon. Rather, it is part of the penetration of kabbalistic—and especially Lurianic kabbalistic—categories, concepts, and practices into popular Jewish piety through various types of manuals composed intentionally to be accessible to a wide audience.³ In a slow process that had come to fruition by the eighteenth century, these manuals called for innovations in the regular liturgy and entirely new ceremonies aimed at mystical achievement (*tikkunim*). Adopting the prescriptive language of halakha, the volumes claimed authority and demanded obedience for the new norms.

Of particular relevance to this workshop is the way in which the new manuals began a process of mapping the commandments according to the parts of the human body. This is already to be found in R. Elazar Azikri's *Sefer Haredim* (Venice 1601)⁴, and was repeated in the very influential work *Shnei Luhot ha-Brit* (SHeLaH; 1648–49) by R. Isaiah Horowitz.⁵ Though the idea was of course not

² Lawrence Fine's *Safed spirituality: rules of mystical piety, the beginning of wisdom* (1984), and his later study, *Physician of the soul, healer of the cosmos : Isaac Luria and his kabbalistic fellowship* (2003).

³ "The Fashioning of Hanhagot (Regimen Vitae) Literature at the End of the Sixteenth Century and During the Seventeenth Century and its Historical Significance / ההיסטוריה עיצוב ספרות ההנהגות העברית במפנה המאה השש עשרה ובמאה השבע עשרה ומשמעותו" *Tarbiz* 56 (1987), pp. 527–581. See also Gries' earlier study, "Hagdarat ha-Hanhaga ke-Sug Sifrut be-Sifrut ha-Musar ha-ivrit," *Kiryat Sefer* 56 (5741), pp. 202–17 and *Sifrut ha-hanhagot: toldoteha u-meḳomah be-ḥaye Ḥaside R. Yiśra'el Ba'al Shem-Ṭov* (1989). Gries understood the popularity of this literature very much within the context of the spreading influence of print: *Ha-Sefer ke-sokhen tarbut ba-shanim 460-660 (1700-1900)* (2002) and ultimately a broader study *ha-Sefer ha-'Ivri : perakim le-toldotay* [=The Hebrew book: an outline of its history] (2015).

⁴ A copy of the Venice 1601 edition of *Sefer Haredim* is viewable at the National Library website: http://rosetta.nli.org.il/delivery/DeliveryManagerServlet?dps_pid=IE12817021.On

⁵ For physical religiosity in שני לוחות הברית, see שער האותיות, the appendix to the first chapter of the book called עשרה מאמרות, from 72a on -- especially p. 74a. under the letter ק taking off from the notion of קדושה and linked to the Genesis verse: ויברא את האדם בצלמו, בצלם אלקים עשה את האדם.

without precedent, the medieval tendency to opt for moderation in all things physical and give precedent to the intellectual (Bahya ibn Paquda's 11th-century *Hovot ha-Levavot*, *The Duties of the Heart* offers a prime example) is now exchanged for emphatic emphasis on the ritualization of the physical and sensual experience. Every body part—from the eyes and ears to the male sexual organ—are included.

In our workshop I would like to explore a little known example of this approach, Joseph Ergas' *Pri Megadim*, a brief work composed about 1703 by the 18-year-old scion of one of the wealthiest Jewish families in Medici Livorno. What is interesting for us is not so much the content of the volume—it is almost entirely a collection of quotations from other authors with almost no original content. Though in later years Ergas would be extolled by Livornese Jewish writers as a great spiritual figure, it seems that the book had very little influence; it remained in manuscript in the family archive until edited and published by a distant relative in 1832.⁶

What is interesting for us to consider in Ergas' little manual is first of all what it tells us about the manner in which kabbalistic practices were studied and spread at least in this corner of the Sephardic diaspora. The book's careful identification and annotation of its sources, down to exact page references for almost every quote, gives testimony to this young man's library and his reading habits. (Note that even though he cites the rule that kabbalah should not be studied before age 20, already at 18 he himself had clearly been pursuing the topic avidly for some time.)

Moreover, Ergas composed his manual to serve as a guide to a circle of young friends that he was gradually forming in Livorno. Just a few years later, this group of youths was sufficiently coherent to gather as a quorum of ten under Ergas' leadership in the city synagogue in order to issue a strict decree of excommunication against the heretical writings of Nehemia Hiya Hayyun. They would also be in a position to persuade the lay leadership of two nearby communities, Florence and Pisa, to issue similar bans. This group of young enthusiasts is strikingly reminiscent of the group of teen-agers who devoted themselves to pious study around another enthusiastic young teacher, Moses Haim Luzzatto (1706–1750), in Padua. When it came to presentation style, there are other interesting links between Ergas and Luzzatto, links that I will try to at least mention in my oral presentation. For now, suffice it to suggest that however derivative this little book, Ergas' focus on ritualizing the physical senses and dedicating the body to religious activity seems to have reflected not just his own

⁶ The catalog of the Israeli National Library lists several nineteenth-century manuscript copies, and the book has been reprinted twice recently, including in a careful edition by Yaakov Moshe Hillel (Jerusalem: Yad Shmuel Franco, 2005–6).

idiosyncracies but also a wave of pietistic enthusiasm that was shaping the religious identities of young Italian Jews in the early 18th century.⁷

Finally, we will note that the text includes more than one statement about public behavior with other Jews, with women, and with non-Jews. To what extent can we read into these injunctions a realistic sense of public behavior in the period?

⁷ For more on the religious atmosphere in Livorno and Pisa at this time, see also my study: “Defining Deviance, Negotiating Norms: Raphael Meldola in Livorno, Pisa, and Bayonne,” in Yosef Kaplan, ed., *Religious Changes and Cultural Transformations in the Early Modern Western Sephardi Communities* (Leiden: Brill, 2018), pp. 157–194.

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Joseph Ergas, *Pri Megadim* (1703; published 1832)

Introduction [to *Pri Megadim*]

Thus says the youth, Joseph son of my father and master, his honor, my teacher and rabbi, Immanuel Ergas, may the memory of a righteous man be a blessing:

[Zohar Hadash 22b]: R. Yosi and R. Hiya both said: it is written [Song of Songs 6:11] "I have gone down to the garden of the nut tree to see the surging of the river." See how much man must think and be punctilious in his heart every day to check his deeds and be very exacting. He must constantly think that the Holy one created him and gave a supernal soul and superiority over all His creatures only so that he think about His worship and communicating with Him. Man must not pursue vanity [i.e., nothingness].

R. Simeon bar Yohai also wrote in Tikunei Zohar VI: Woe to us people that the Holy One Blessed be He is trapped in exile with us, and the Shehina is imprisoned with us. It is said, a prisoner cannot free himself from jail. His salvation is that repentance which is in your hands. He turns here and there trying to find someone who will repent and break the prison...

And when I read these words, I started to tremble and I was very frightened. I said: Woe to us whose generation is not worthy, and the fingernail of the first ones is superior to the entirety [literally: the belly] of the later ones.¹ For because of this long bitter exile which is caused by the spread and strengthening of the impurity of the Snake, we have to create more fences and hedges so that no stranger (i.e., the force of the shell) shall mix with the sacred.

Negative Commandments Dependent Upon the "Eyes" [Vision]

It is forbidden to look at women. We read in Tractate Avoda Zara fol. 20a: It happened that Rabbi Simeon ben Gamliel was standing on a step on the Temple Mount and saw a non-Jewish woman who was especially beautiful. He said: 'How

¹ This phrase from BT Yoma 10b refers specifically to a discussion of the length of the current exile.

great are Your deeds, o Lord.² [The Talmud then] asks: And is it [indeed] permitted to look? The braitā quotes the verse 'And you shall keep yourself from every evil thing'³ This means that a person should not gaze upon a beautiful woman even if she is unmarried, nor upon a married woman even she is ugly, nor upon a woman's colored garments, nor upon domesticated or wild animal[s] or bird[s] when they are copulating, etc." And [Rabbi Simeon ben Gamliel] replied: "It happened at a corner [i.e., he came around a corner and came upon her suddenly and didn't have a chance to close his eyes—RaSHI].⁴ ... Owing to our current sinful state [literally: because of our many sins], this prohibition of looking at women has become, for people of our generation, absolutely permitted, and when a woman walks down the city streets, people watch her, look her up and down from her soles to her head. As if that were not enough, they go to theatres (טרטריאות וקרקסיות) that the gentiles sponsor called "comedies." They sit there for 3 or 4 hours to listen to women singing. Because of our multiplying sins, there are some among the learned [maskilim] and those who are called wise [hakham] who fail in this sin, and their eyes are too bleary to see and understand how many prohibitions are involved in this matter. I will add further that it says in Tractate Kiddushin fol. 70a: Rabbi Nahman said to Rabbi Judah, 'Would the master send regards to my wife, Yalta?' He replied, "Thus said Samuel: a woman's voice is like nakedness."⁵ „„ [Ergas quotes RaSHI's explanation:] "The voice of a woman is like nakedness. As it is said (Song of Songs 2:14): 'Let me hear your voice.' And if I ask about her state, she will answer." Thus we see that it is forbidden to listen even to the voice of a modest woman answering someone who asked how she was; how much ore is it true that it is forbidden to listen to the voice of a gentile woman who is singing about vulgar, sexual matters that penetrate the body of the hearer like a viper's poison.... And enough of this, since it has already been treated at length in the Zohar and the ethical tracts about the seriousness of this sin. One must therefore be very careful.

Negative Commandments Dependent Upon the Nose [Smell]

§67 *Lo tin'af*: Thou shalt not commit adultery [Exodus 20:12 and Deut. 5:16] can be read *lo tehe ne la-af*—i.e., “do not give pleasure to the nose” לא תהנה לאף. The commentators have explained that this means that it is forbidden to smell the perfume of a married woman or other forbidden women.

2 Ps 104:24.

3 Deuteronomy 23:10

4 Interestingly, the Talmud goes on in some detail to discuss how impractical and unenforceable these rules are; Ergas omits that discussion.

5 I.e., he didn't want to send regards to Rabbi Nahman's wife since she might respond and the bearer of the message would then be exposed to the woman's voice.

Negative Commandments Dependent Upon the Mouth and Throat

§114 A father or mother should not frighten their children with something impure, as when you might say a cat or a dog or a gentile [כּוֹתֵי] will get you, for a covenant is made with the lips, and God forbid, immediately the shell (קְלִיפָה) where those impure names [i.e. forces] are located will come. There is a danger of harm to the child in this world as well as injury to his soul. He who worries about his soul will distance himself from such practices. This is understood to “scholars of the truth” [i.e. kabbalists].

Isaiah Horowitz, *Shnei Luhot ha-Brit [SHeLaH]*, p. 64.

Negative Commandments Dependent Upon the Esophagus.

§162 Thou shalt be Holy. Holiness about which we have been commanded is [equivalent to] asceticism. One should restrain oneself and forego [satisfying] desires, even with regard to that which is [halakhically] permitted. As [the Sages] said: "Sanctify yourself with what is permitted you."⁶ With regard to food and drink, this means one should eat and drink less than is appropriate [or: usual] of that which is permitted; he should not go beyond what is necessary for maintaining the body. Similarly with regard to sexual relations for the purpose of maintaining the species or in order to fulfil what one owes his wife or to save oneself from having [evil] thoughts. Anything more beyond such purposes is forbidden biblically. Similar with regard to speech that is necessary for making a livelihood and so forth. He should restrain himself in his words, uttering them in a balanced way and less than is appropriate [or: usual] in order to attain the level of great asceticism. He should never engage in frivolous conversation. (And see Nahmanides' on the pericope Kdoshim [Leviticus 19:1–20:27].)

Behaye ben Asher, *Kad ha-Kemah*, s.v. "Kedusha."

§163 Whatever a man eats on a weekday over and above what is appropriate for survival of his soul is considered "dung from your festival [sacrifices]"⁷ and [consumign it] adds strength to the "external" [forces].

Writings of Isaac Luria

....

§165 One must be careful of taking pleasure during eating, drinking, and intercourse. Rather, one must act as if forced by a devil that was compelling him to eat or have intercourse, and [to feel that] he would be very content were it possible

6 Yevamot 20a.

7 Malachi 2:3

to exist without that food and drink or to be fruitful and multiply without that intercourse.

[Joseph Karo, *Magid Mesharim*, p. 2a.]

Positive Commandments Dependent Upon the Nose.

§65. One should try to have 3 [stalks of] myrtle on the Sabbath, tied into a single posie to sniff. Certainly, the best is to have three thick ones, but even if you can't find thick ones be sure to have at eat three twigs tied into a single bunch, for this hints at the three Forefathers.

Elijah di Vidas, *Toza'ot Hayim*, p. 17.

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הקדמה

אמר הצעיר יוסף בלא"א כמוהר"ר עמנואל אירגאס זצ"ל:

איתא בזהר חדש דף כ"ב ע"ב וז"ל, רבי יוסי ורבי חייא אמרי תרווייהו כתיב (שיר השירים ו' י"א) אל גינת אגוז ירדתי לראות באבי הנחל. ראה כמה יש לו לאדם להרהר ולדקדק בלבו בכל יום ויום ולפשפש במעשיו ולדקדק בכל עניו, ויהרהר בלבו שלא בראו הק"ה ונתן בו נשמה עליונה ומעלה על שאר בריותיו אלא להרהר לעבודתו ולהדבר בו ולא ילך אחרי ההבל.

...

עוד כתב הרשב"י זלה"ה בס' התיקונים בתקון ששי דף י"ז וז"ל: ווי לון לבני נשא דקב"ה אסיר עמהון בגלותא, ושכינתא אסירת עמהון, ואתמר בה אין חבוש מתיר עצמו מבית האסורים. ופורקנא דילה דאיהי תשובה אימה עילאה, איהי תליא בידיהון וכו'. ויפן כה וכה, אם אית מאן דאתעד בתיובתא לתברא ביה אסורין דלהון...

ובקוראי אלה הדברים עמדתי מרעיד זחלתי ואירא מאד, אמרתי ווי לן דלא אכשר דרי, וטובה צפורן של ראשונים מכריסם של אחרונים... כי באריכות הגלות המר הזה שהוא ע"י התפשטות והתגברות זוהמת הנחש צריכין אנו לעשות יותר גדרים וסייגים לבל התערב זר הוא כח הקליפה בקדושה...

מה) אסור להסתכל בנשים. וגרסינן במסכת ע"ז דף כ' [ע"א] מעשה ברשב"ג שהיה על גב מעלה בהר הבית וראה גויה אחת נאה ביותר אמר מה רבו מעשיך ה', ופריך ולאסתכולי מי שרי מתיבי ונשמרת מכל דבר רע שלא יסתכל אדם באשה נאה ואפילו פנויה, באשת איש ואפילו מכווערת, ולא בבגדי צבע [של] אשה, ולא בבהמה חיה ועוף בזמן שנזקקין זה לזה וכו', ותיריך קרן זוית הואי. פירש"י [ד"ה קרן] קרן זוית הואי, כשפונין לימין או לשמאל ליכנס ממבוי למבוי ופוגעין זה את זה בקרן זוית דאינו רואה אותה מרחוק באה כנגדו שיעצם עיניו, עכ"ל. וכתבו שם התוס' [ד"ה שלא] דהאי קרא דונשמרת וכו' דרשה גמורה היא ולא אסמכתא, ע"ש. והנה בעו"ה איסור זה של הסתכלות בנשים נעשה להם לאנשי דורנו היתר גמור, ומידי עבור אשה ברחובות קריה אליה ישגיחו אליה יתבוננו מכף רגל ועד ראש. ולא די להם זה אלא שהולכים לטרטריאות וקרקסיות שעושים הגוים שקורין קומידיא"ס, ויושבים שם שלש או ארבע שעות לשמוע בקול נשים משוררות. ובעונותינו שרבו יש קצת משכילים וגם מהנקראים בשם חכם שנכשלים בזה העון, ועיניהם טחו מלראות ולהבין כמה איסורים יש בדבר הזה, וכמו שהארכתי במקום אחר.

ולבד זה אומר כאן דאיתא במסכת קדושין דף ע' [ע"א] א"ל רב נחמן לרב יהודה לשדר מר שלמא לילתא, א"ל הכי אמר שמואל קול באשה ערוה. פירש"י לילתא, שם אשתו. קול באשה ערוה, שנאמר [ש"ה"ש ב' י"ד] השמיעני את קולך ואם אשאל בשלומה תשיבני, עכ"ל. הרי דאסור לשמוע אפילו קול אשה צנועה המשיבה לשואל בשלומה, כ"ש וק"ו דאסור לשמוע קול אשה גויה המשוררת דברי נבלות ונאופים הנכנסים בגוף השומע[י]ם כארס של עכנאי. וגם בפ' במה בהמה [שבת ס"ד ע"א] ארז"ל על פסוק [במדבר ל"א י"ד] ויקצוף משה על פקודי החיל, אמר להם משה לישראל חזרתם לקלוקלכם הראשון וכו', אמרו לו אם מידי עבירה יצאנו מידי הרהור לא יצאנו, מיד ונקרב את קרבן ה'. תנא דבי ר' ישמעאל מפני מה הוצרכו ישראל שבאותו הדור כפרה מפני שזנו עיניהם מן הערוה. ודי בזה כי כבר האריכו בזוהר ובספרי המוסר בחומר העון הזה ולכן צריך לזהר מאד.

מצות לא תעשה התלויות בחוטם
ס"ז] לא תנאף נוטריקון לא תהנה לאף. ופירשו המפרשים שר"ל שאסור להריח ריח אשת איש המבושמת וכן בשאר עריות. ספר החרדים דף ל"ו.

מצות לא תעשה התלויות בפה וקנה
קיד] יזהרו אב ואם שלא יעשו מורא לתינוק בדבר טמא, כגון לומר חתול או כלב או כותי תקח זה התינוק, כי ברית כרותה לשפתים ובר מינן תכף הקליפה אשר שם שמות הטומאה ההם מצויים יבואו ויש חשש היזק לתינוק בזה"ז וגם פגם לנשמתו, ע"כ שומר נפשו ירחק מהם. ודבר זה מבואר לחכמי האמת. של"ה דף ס"ד.

מצות לא תעשה התלויות בושט
קס"ב] קדושים תהיו, ענין הקדושה הזאת שנצטוינו בה הוא הפרישות שיגדור אדם את עצמו ושיפרוש מן התאוות אפילו ממה שאמרו שהוא מותר, כמאמרם ז"ל [יבמות כ ע"א] קדש עצמך במותר לך. וזה בענין המאכל והמשתה שיאכל וישתה מן המותר פחות ממה שראוי ולא יתכוין אלא לקיום הגוף בלבד וכן בענין המשגל לצורך קיום המין או למצות עונה או להנצל מהרהור, וכל השאר זולתי לכוונת אלו אסור מדין התורה. וכן בענין דבורו הצרכי לפרנסתו וכיוצא, שיגדור את עצמו בדבריו להוציאם במשקל ופחות הן הראוי עד שיגיע אל פרישות רב שלא ישוח שיחה בטלה מימיו. (ועיין בפרשת קדושים להרמב"ן ז"ל). כד הקמח אות קדושה.
קס"ג] כל מה שאוכל האדם בחול יותר ממה שראוי להתקיים נפשו נקרא פרש חגיכם [מלאכי ב' ג'] ומוסי, כח אל החיצונים. כתבי האר"י.

...

קס"ה] צריך לזהר מלהתענג בעת המאכל והמשתה ובעת התשמיש, רק יהיה כמי שכפאו שד ומכריחו על המאכל ההוא או על התשמיש ההוא, ואם היה אפשר להתקיים זולת המאכל והמשתה ולפרות ולרבות זולת התשמיש היה חפץ מאד. נגעד נעשרען דך ב'.

מצות עשה התלויות בחוטם

סח] ישתדל שיהיו לו בשבת ג' הדסים עשויות בקשר אחד להריח בהם, ובודאי אם יצמא ג' ועבות טוב
מאד, ואם לא ימצא עבות לא יפחת מג' בדים בקשר אחד שהם רמז לג' אבות. תוצאות חיים, דף י"ז.